

GoldLeaf Packaging Complete AEO Playbook

Your customers are asking AI for packaging recommendations.
Right now, GoldLeaf doesn't show up. Your competitors will.

PREPARED FOR

GoldLeaf Marketing Agency Call

DATE

February 10, 2026

SITE

goldleafpackaging.com

CURRENT SCORE

46/100 — Grade F

TARGET SCORE

80+ (Grade B)

PAGES SCANNED

55 of 55 (complete)



Executive Summary

Situation: GoldLeaf's website is invisible to AI search engines. When potential customers ask ChatGPT, Perplexity, or Google AI *"Who makes custom packaging in Birmingham?"* or *"Best digital printing for food packaging,"* GoldLeaf doesn't appear in the answer.

Why: We scanned all **55 pages** on the site. The average score is **46/100 (Grade F)**. Zero of the 55 pages contain structured data. 44 pages have no FAQ content. 38 pages have no lists or tables. 19 pages have missing or weak meta descriptions.

The opportunity: GoldLeaf has strong content — 826 words on the homepage, 1,006 on /about, 38 blog posts, 13 FAQ questions, and proper contact info (address, phone, email) in crawlable HTML on every page. 3 blog posts already score 80/100 and just need schema markup to hit 100. Most competitors haven't addressed AEO at all. Gartner projects AI search will capture 25% of commercial queries by end of 2026 — every month GoldLeaf stays invisible is pipeline you're handing to competitors who show up first.

The plan: 15 prioritized fixes organized in 4 tiers. Focus Tier 1 first (llms.txt, schema markup, FAQ sections, content restructuring) — these 4 items drive 80% of the score improvement. A 4-week roadmap moves GoldLeaf from 46 to 88+ (Grade B).

What we need today: Approval to begin Week 1 (foundation fixes, ~5 hours effort). That alone moves the score from 46 to 60. The full 4-week roadmap totals ~40 hours across Agency, Dev, and Content roles. Start this week and GoldLeaf will be cited in AI search results by mid-March.

Full Site Scan Results (55 Pages)

CHECK	PASSING	FAILING	PASS RATE
Heading Structure	48	7	87%
Meta Description	36	19	65%
Schema Markup	0	55	0%
FAQ Section	11	44	20%
Content Structure	17	38	31%

Bright Spot: 3 Pages Already at 80/100

These blog posts pass 4 of 5 checks — adding BlogPosting schema would push them to 100/100:

1. Choosing the Right Packaging for Your Wellness Brand (1,445 words, 15 lists)
2. How to Design a Product Label (1,667 words, 6 lists)
3. The Ultimate Guide to Brochure Printing (1,175 words, 10 lists)

Quick win: Add BlogPosting schema to these 3 pages first — 30 minutes of dev work to create 3 perfect-score pages.

What Is AEO?

Your customers are already asking ChatGPT and Perplexity questions like *"best packaging companies in Alabama"* and *"custom box printing near me."* Right now, GoldLeaf isn't showing up in those answers — but your competitors could be.

AEO (Answer Engine Optimization) is how you fix that. AI search engines don't show 10 blue links. They read your site, decide whether your content is trustworthy, and either cite you in their answers or ignore you completely. This playbook shows you exactly how to get cited.

Beyond the Scanner

We scanned all 55 pages on the site. The average score is 46/100 — but 3 blog posts already hit 80. That's fixable, and fast. This playbook covers all **15 signals** AI engines use to decide whether to cite you, organized by impact. Follow the 4-week roadmap and you'll hit 88+ site-wide before the end of March.

TIER 1 Critical — Currently Failing

These 4 fixes will move the needle fastest. They address the foundational signals AI engines check first — structured data, explicit metadata, and content formatting. Together they unlock 80% of the score improvement. Without these, Tier 2–4 optimizations have limited impact. **Combined impact: +40 points across all 55 pages.**

1. Add llms.txt File

Missing (404)

99% of your competitors don't have this yet. It's a plain text file that tells AI systems exactly what GoldLeaf does — think of it as a "README for robots." Adopted by Anthropic, Perplexity, and hundreds of enterprise sites in 2025. 30 minutes to create, massive citation boost.

Recommended Content:

GoldLeaf Print & Packaging

About

GoldLeaf Print & Packaging is a US-based premium custom printing company headquartered in Birmingham, Alabama. Founded on the belief that digital printing would be the future, GoldLeaf has served over 3,200 clients and printed more than 4.3 million items. The team has 50+ years of collective experience in digital print technology.

Services

- Primary Packaging: Custom designed and printed packaging
- Custom Boxes: Any shape or size, fully custom printed
- Labels & Application: Design, print, and application services
- Business Essentials: Business cards, signage, collateral
- Promotional Items: Custom-branded apparel and merchandise

Technology

- DigiFLO: Proprietary platform for streamlined ordering
- Digital foil and varnish embellishment capabilities
- Low minimum order quantities
- US-based manufacturing

Content Policies

AI systems may cite and reference our content with attribution.

30 min effort

High impact

2. Add Schema Markup (JSON-LD) — Site-Wide

0/20 on all 55 pages

This is the single biggest problem. Zero structured data on any of the 55 pages scanned. Structured data is the language AI engines speak — without it, they can't understand what GoldLeaf does or when to cite you. **This alone is worth +20 points per page.**

The good news: your site footer already has the right contact data in crawlable HTML (Birmingham, AL address, phone, email on every page). The schema just needs to formalize what's already there so AI engines can parse it reliably. **No visual changes required** — schema lives in the source code, invisible to visitors. Zero design impact.

Required schema types:

SCHEMA TYPE	WHERE	PURPOSE
Organization	Every page (global template)	Business identity, logo, contact
LocalBusiness	Homepage	Location, hours, service area
FAQPage	/faq + pages with Q&A	Question-answer citation
Service	Each service page	Service descriptions
BlogPosting	Each blog post	Article metadata, author, date
BreadcrumbList	All pages	Site navigation structure

Example — Organization (goes on every page):

```
{
  "@context": "https://schema.org",
  "@type": "Organization",
  "name": "GoldLeaf Print & Packaging",
  "url": "https://www.goldleafpackaging.com",
  "logo": "https://www.goldleafpackaging.com/logo.png",
  "description": "US-based premium custom printing company...",
  "address": {
    "@type": "PostalAddress",
    "addressLocality": "Birmingham",
    "addressRegion": "AL",
    "addressCountry": "US"
  }
}
```

4-6 hours effort

+20 pts per page

3. Add FAQ Sections to Service Pages

44/55 pages have no FAQ content

You already wrote 13 great FAQ answers — but they're all buried on one page. AI engines don't find them there. Move them to the service pages where customers actually search, and watch citation rates spike.

FAQ templates by page:

PAGE	SAMPLE QUESTIONS
/services/custom-boxes	What types of custom boxes can GoldLeaf produce? What is the minimum order quantity? What materials and finishes are available? How long does production take?
/services/labels-application	What label materials do you offer? Do you provide application services? What file formats do you accept? Can you print variable data?
/services/primary-packaging	What types of primary packaging can you produce? What industries do you serve? Do you offer food-safe options?
/digiflo	What is DigiFLO? How does it streamline reordering? Is it available for all customers?

4-6 hours effort

+20 pts per page

4. Restructure Content with Lists and Tables

38/55 pages have zero lists or tables

78% of AI citations use lists or tables. GoldLeaf has all the right content — it's just in paragraph form, which AI engines skip over. Reformatting existing content into lists takes 3–4 hours and unlocks +20 points per page.

High-priority pages:

PAGE	WORDS	LISTS	NEEDED
Homepage	826	0	Service offerings as bullet list
/about	1,006	0	Capabilities + team info need lists
/digiflo	794	0	Feature list as bullets
/services (all)	~300 each	0	Specs, materials, capabilities lists
/blog-posts/10-things-labels	1,296	0	Perfect numbered list opportunity

3-4 hours effort
+20 pts per page

TIER 2 Important — Missing Infrastructure

These fixes don't show up in the scanner, but they control whether AI engines crawl your site in the first place. Think of Tier 1 as "make content understandable" and Tier 2 as "make content accessible." Without them, you're invisible no matter how good your content is.

5. Update robots.txt — Explicitly Allow AI Crawlers

Current: only Sitemap line

Many sites accidentally block AI crawlers. Being explicit guarantees your content gets indexed.

```
User-agent: *  
Allow: /  
  
# AI Search Engines - Explicitly Allowed  
User-agent: GPTBot  
Allow: /  
  
User-agent: Google-Extended  
Allow: /  
  
User-agent: anthropic-ai  
Allow: /  
  
User-agent: ClaudeBot  
Allow: /  
  
User-agent: PerplexityBot  
Allow: /  
  
Sitemap: https://www.goldleafpackaging.com/sitemap.xml
```

10 min effort

Medium impact

6. Add Open Graph and Twitter Card Meta Tags

Not detected on any page

AI systems that surface web results (Perplexity, Bing Copilot) use OG data for rich previews. No OG tags = plain text links that get less attention.

```
<meta property="og:title" content="Custom Box Printing | GoldLeaf">  
<meta property="og:description" content="Custom designed boxes...">  
<meta property="og:image" content="../../../custom-boxes-og.jpg">  
<meta property="og:url" content="../../../services/custom-boxes">  
<meta name="twitter:card" content="summary_large_image">
```

1-2 hours effort

Medium impact

7. Add Canonical URLs

Not detected

The site redirects goldleafpackaging.com → www.goldleafpackaging.com. Without canonical URLs, AI engines may split citation authority between duplicates.

```
<link rel="canonical" href="https://www.goldleafpackaging.com/services/custom-
```

30 min effort

Medium impact

8. Enhance Sitemap with Metadata

Exists (56 URLs) but zero metadata

AI crawlers use `lastmod` to prioritize fresh content. The sitemap has 56 URLs but no `lastmod`, `changefreq`, or `priority` values.

1 hour effort

Medium impact

TIER 3 E-E-A-T Signals — Authority Building

Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness — the signals AI uses to decide if GoldLeaf is credible. Without these, you may show up in AI search but not get cited. These signals separate GoldLeaf from anonymous blogs and offshore printers.

9. Add Author Attribution to Blog Posts

No author names on any content

Anonymous blog posts score lower than attributed ones. Add bylines ("By [Name], [Title] at GoldLeaf"), Person schema, and LinkedIn links.

1-2 hours effort

Medium impact

10. Add Publication and Update Dates

No visible dates on any content

AI systems prioritize fresh content. Blog posts with no date are treated as potentially outdated. Add publication dates visibly and in `datePublished` / `dateModified` schema.

1 hour effort

Medium impact

11. Surface Awards and Certifications

"Award-winning" is mentioned but no specific awards are displayed. The /about page mentions "50 years of collective experience" and "3.2k Clients / 4.3m Items" — great proof points that should be structured and highlighted.

1 hour effort

Medium impact

12. Improve Image Alt Text

Most images lack descriptive alt attributes

Bad: `alt=""` Good: `alt="Custom printed folding carton box with UV spot coating and gold foil stamping by GoldLeaf Print & Packaging"`

2-3 hours effort

Low-Medium impact

TIER 4

Content Strategy — Ongoing

Long-term content investments that compound over time. Once the technical foundation is in place (Tiers 1–3), this is how GoldLeaf becomes the authority that AI engines cite for packaging topics in Alabama and beyond.

13. Write "Answer-First" Content

AI engines extract direct answers. Content that leads with the answer gets cited more.

Current style: *"In the world of packaging, there are many factors to consider..."*

AEO-optimized: *"The best packaging materials for food products are: kraft paper, corrugated cardboard, and food-grade polyethylene. Here's when to use each..."*

14. Create "Best Of" and Comparison Content

Target the exact queries people ask AI assistants:

- "Best Packaging Materials for [Industry]" (cannabis, food, cosmetics)
- "Digital vs. Offset Printing: Which Is Right for Your Packaging?"
- "Custom Box Types: A Complete Guide"
- "Label Materials Compared: Paper vs. Film vs. Synthetic"

15. Add a Glossary or Knowledge Base

A [/glossary](#) page defining printing terms (GSM, dieline, substrate, CMYK, spot UV, etc.) creates dozens of citable definitions. AI systems frequently cite glossary entries.

Fix the Small Stuff

ISSUE	PAGE	FIX
"GoldLead" typo	/blog meta description	Change to "GoldLeaf"
Missing H1	/careers, /privacy-policy, /terms + 4 others	Add H1 heading (7 pages)
6 H1 tags	/blog-posts/american-excellence	Demote 5 to H2
H1→H3 skip	/blog	Change card headings to H2

ISSUE	PAGE	FIX
Missing/short meta	19 pages across site	Add or expand to 120-160 chars

Implementation Roadmap

Four weeks, four milestones, 85+ score at the end. Each week builds on the last. Start Week 1 this week and GoldLeaf will be cited in AI search by mid-March.

Week 1 (Feb 10–14): Foundation — Target: 46 → 60

TASK	OWNER	HOURS
Create and deploy llms.txt	Agency	0.5
Update robots.txt with AI bot directives	Agency	0.25
Add Organization JSON-LD to site template	Agency/Dev	1
Add canonical URLs to template	Agency/Dev	0.5
Fix heading structure (7 pages)	Agency	0.5
Fix meta descriptions (19 pages)	Agency	2
Fix "GoldLead" typo	Agency	0.1

Week 2 (Feb 17–21): Schema + OG Tags — Target: 60 → 72

TASK	OWNER	HOURS
Add LocalBusiness schema to homepage	Dev	0.5
Add FAQPage schema to /faq	Dev	0.5
Add Service schema to 6 service pages	Dev	2
Add BlogPosting schema to 38 blog posts	Dev	3
Add BreadcrumbList schema to all pages	Dev	1

TASK	OWNER	HOURS
Add OG + Twitter meta tags (template)	Dev	1
Enhance sitemap with lastmod/priority	Dev	1

Week 3 (Feb 24–28): Content Restructuring — Target: 72 → 82

TASK	OWNER	HOURS
Add bullet lists to homepage	Content	1
Reformat service pages with specs lists	Content	3
Reformat "10 Things" blog as numbered list	Content	0.5
Add bullet lists to /about, /digiflo	Content	1
Add publication dates to blog posts	Content	1
Improve image alt text site-wide	Content	3
Add author bylines to blog posts	Content	1

Week 4 (Mar 3–7): FAQ Expansion — Target: 82 → 88+

TASK	OWNER	HOURS
Write FAQ sections for 6 service pages	Content	4
Write FAQ sections for top blog posts	Content	3
Add FAQPage schema to new FAQ sections	Dev	1
Create answer-first summaries on top blogs	Content	2
Surface awards/certifications on /about	Content	1

What Happens If We Wait?

AI search adoption is accelerating. Every month without AEO optimization:

- Competitors who add schema first will own the citation slots GoldLeaf should have

- AI models are trained on current data — the longer GoldLeaf is absent, the harder it is to catch up
- "Custom packaging Birmingham" queries increasingly go to AI answers instead of Google results
- The 3 blog posts scoring 80/100 today could be at 100 in 30 minutes of dev work — every day they sit at 80 is a missed citation

What We Need From This Call

Option A (Recommended): Approve the full 4-week roadmap. ~40 hours total across Agency, Dev, and Content. Score moves from 46 → 88+ across all 55 pages.

Option B: Approve Week 1 only (~5 hours, Agency + Dev). Score moves from 46 → 60. Re-scan after Week 1 to validate the lift before committing to Weeks 2–4.

Next step: Confirm which option, assign Agency/Dev/Content owners by name, and agree on a Week 1 start date.

Projected Score Trajectory

Four weeks from now, GoldLeaf will outrank 90% of custom printers in AI search.

MILESTONE	SCORE	GRADE	TIMELINE
Current (55 pages)	46	F	Today (Feb 10)
After Week 1	~60	D	Feb 14
After Week 2	~72	C	Feb 21
After Week 3	~82	B	Feb 28
After Week 4	~88	B+	Mar 7

How to Verify Progress

Re-scan after each phase using the AEO Scanner at: bai-aeo.vercel.app

Enter `goldleafpackaging.com` → Full Site scan → Compare scores.

The scanner checks 5 of the 15 signals above. For the others (llms.txt, robots.txt, OG tags, canonical URLs, alt text, E-E-A-T), manual verification or a follow-up audit session.

GoldLeaf Print & Packaging

goldleafpackaging.com

Birmingham, Alabama — Premium Custom Printing